

The conception that the writers of these prophecies are unknown, and that they lived in Babylon, directly contradicts the Scriptures. The latter half of Isaiah equally with the first is assigned to that prophet in the Old Testament, and is constantly cited under his name in the New; and the prophecies in the thirteenth and fourteenth chapters are not only included in the book of Isaiah, but are expressly entitled, "The burden of Babylon, which Isaiah the son of Amoz did see."

The prophecy in the fiftieth and fifty-first chapters of Jeremiah is introduced in the first verse with the words, "The word that the Lord spake against Babylon, and against the land of the Chaldeans, by Jeremiah the prophet." After the close of the prophecy we read, "So Jeremiah wrote in a book all the evil that should come upon Babylon, even all these words that are written against Babylon. And Jeremiah said to Seraiah, When thou comest to Babylon, and shalt see, and shalt read all these words; then shalt thou say, O Lord, thou hast spoken against this place, to cut it off, that none shall remain in it, neither man nor beast, but that it shall be desolate for ever. And it shall be, when thou hast made an end of reading this book, that thou shalt bind a stone to it, and cast it into the midst of Euphrates: and thou shalt say, Thus shall Babylon sink, and shall not rise from the evil that I will bring upon her: and they shall be weary. Thus far are the words of Jeremiah" (vers. 60-64).

Four times this prophecy is expressly ascribed to Jeremiah, and not merely in the title, but in the narrative; but notwithstanding the clear testimony of Scripture, Kuenen, Reuss, and other critics, some with more and others with less hesitation, ascribe it to an anonymous exile in Babylon. Ewald calls it "the earliest example of a piece written in the name of one of Israel's older prophets;" and Professor Oort, taking the same ground, writes with profane boldness, as if he had been in Babylon and had seen it all: "One of the exiles composed an elaborate oracle on the humiliation which the Chaldean gods and Babylon itself would endure

because Nebuchadnezzar had shattered Israel. The writer put this prediction into the mouth of Jeremiah, and declared that this man of God wrote it during the fourth year of Zedekiah's reign." This view makes the whole prophecy a deliberate forgery, and not only worthless but detestable.

More reverent critics satisfy themselves with calling the writer anonymous; an affirmation directly contrary to the Bible, which states repeatedly that the writer was Jeremiah. A recognition of that prophet as the author is incompatible with any theory that would limit such predictions to nearly approaching events. But to call the prophecy anonymous is a misapplication of language, for its author could not be named either more expressly or more fully; and if it was not written by Jeremiah, the circumstantial narrative of its origin and history cannot have been a mistake, but is a deliberate falsehood embodied in the sacred writings.

For the existence of such anonymous prophets, either one or several, in Babylon during the exile there is not the faintest trace of historical proof, either as regards the prophets themselves, or the effect of their writings on the people at the time, or on the memories of the nation. Confessedly there is no such evidence outside the Bible; and the Bible itself, as we have seen, gives no ground and leaves no room for the supposition. The Scriptural prophecies against Babylon, far from being nameless, are expressly assigned to two of the greatest names in the roll of the prophets, Isaiah and Jeremiah; and there is not the slightest intimation of the existence of a single anonymous prophet in Babylon. At the beginning of the exile there were false prophets there; and their names are not only recorded, but were handed down with a note of infamy in the lips of the exiles. In the period of Exile there lived two great prophets in Babylon, Ezekiel and Daniel, one in the city, and the other in the kingdom; their names are attached to their prophecies, and have come down to us among the great prophets of Scripture. Of anonymous prophets in Babylon, either one or more, either true or false, Scripture acknowledges none.

CHAPTER II.

*THE RESPECTFUL LOYALTY OF THE KNOWN EXILE
PROPHETS TO THE CHALDEAN KINGS.*

WHEN we are asked to believe in supposititious prophets of whom we have no record in Scripture and no tradition out of it, our first recourse is to the known prophets of the period, that by comparing them together we may ascertain if the new conception is consistent with history and in so far worthy of consideration, or if it is a hasty and crude idea with no verisimilitude to commend it.

Now, in striking contrast to the character and conduct of the fictitious prophets of the critics, one of the most deeply marked features of the historical prophets in Babylon is their fidelity to the Chaldean kings. The exiles in Babylon and the prophets who lived amongst them found themselves placed under a very peculiar dispensation of Divine providence. They were exiled not only from their own land, but from the house of their God and His consecrated dwelling in the earth; and although the holy temple was now lying desolate, its stones were dear to them, not merely for the memories of the past, but for the hopes of the future, when it should be raised again from its ruins. Daniel in Babylon prayed with his windows open towards Jerusalem. The captives of Judah had from the beginning of their exile the Divine promise of a sure return to their own land after the lapse of seventy years; and they refused to sing in the land of their bondage the joyful songs of the Lord's house, counting it better for their tongue to cleave to the roof of their mouth than for them to forget Jerusalem. It was the

Lord's will that they should never reckon themselves at home in Babylon; but always remain strangers, even as the followers of Christ are now pilgrims in the earth, looking for their own city in the better country above.

But while the Jews were, therefore, never to intermingle and unite with the Chaldeans, they were expressly commanded to seek the peace of Babylon, to give their sons and their daughters in marriage, to build houses and dwell in them, to plant gardens and eat the fruit of them, in that vast city within whose walls the reaper "handled the sickle in the time of harvest." They were to be in all respects peaceful, dutiful, and loyal subjects of the kingdom in which they were captives; not to conspire against it or make efforts for its overthrow, but to promote its welfare and pray for its safety.

This double attitude of intense affection for their own land and of true loyalty to the land of their exile was very peculiar; yet the ordained duty to both was plain and unmistakable, and its fulfilment is clearly brought out in the exiles with whose history we are best acquainted, Daniel and his three companions, and the prophet Ezekiel.

1. *The Book of Daniel.*—The historical truth of this book is denied by most of the critics who hold that the prophecies of Isaiah and Jeremiah against Babylon are not authentic, and to any argument derived from it they will attach no weight; but for those who duly reverence all the Holy Scriptures, it is interesting to note the beautiful consistency and harmony of the whole.

Daniel and his friends in exile accept of high offices in the government of the Chaldean kingdom. Against the three noble youths who were set over the province of Babylon their enemies can bring no charge of unfaithfulness or disloyalty, and they can only accuse them of supreme devotion to the living God. In Daniel the most steadfast fidelity to his God and his country is combined with the most faithful loyalty to the King of Babylon. When he is called to interpret Nebuchadnezzar's dream, he opens

the interpretation of the Divine judgment that is to fall upon him with the dutiful and kindly preface: "My lord, the dream be to them that hate thee, and the interpretation thereof to thine enemies;" and concludes it with a respectful counsel of repentance, "if it might be a lengthening of his tranquillity."

At Belshazzar's feast, while the revelry is resounding through the palace, the enemy is already stealing into the city by the bed of the river; but even in that last night of the Chaldean kingdom, it is at the king's command, and not from his own impulse, that Daniel interprets the mysterious handwriting on the wall. He boldly reproves the king for the sins that had provoked the Most High to stretch out the hand that wrote his doom over against the candlestick that lighted the banquet hall; but he neither invokes the Divine vengeance on Babylon, nor afterwards refuses the high honours with which the king proceeds to invest him.

In the sequel, when the Chaldean dominion has been quite overthrown, and when he understands, by the Sacred Books, that the time has come for the restoration of Zion, he obeys the Lord's command by Jeremiah: "Then shall ye go and pray unto me, and I will hearken unto you, and I will turn away your captivity;" and he sets himself to seek God by prayer and supplication for the desired deliverance. But he uses no other means except prayer when God's full time had come; and during the whole Chaldean dominion he never denounces the government under which he lived, and which he served for seventy years.

2. *The Book of Ezekiel*.—The other Babylonian prophet, Ezekiel, is acknowledged by all the critics, however extreme, as one of the exiles; and of all the exiles the prophet on the banks of the Chebar was best entitled to claim toleration in foretelling the fall of the power under which he dwelt, because in the earlier years of his own captivity he had faithfully warned his countrymen that Jerusalem would be delivered into the hands of the Chaldeans. But as well after the taking of the city as before it, we find in him

the very same attitude as in Daniel toward Israel and toward Babylon ; of ardent attachment to his land and to his people, and of the most perfect loyalty to the government under which he lives as a captive.

The delicate handling of prophetic truth, as affecting this double relation, is brought out in a most remarkable manner in the thirty-sixth chapter of his prophecies. The prophet has uttered his oracles against the heathen nations, against Moab and Ammon, against Tyre and Sidon, against Philistia, Edom, and Egypt. Babylon alone has been omitted, and it may be said not unnaturally hitherto, because Babylon is the instrument of Divine judgment against these seven nations. But the prophecy in the thirty-sixth chapter is for the land of Israel, which is now desolate, and has been laid waste for years under the destroying sway of Babylon. This prophecy contains a promise of a new heart and other promises for Israel, that stretch onward past our own time ; but its predictions are very specific on the return of the people, the rebuilding of the cities, and the restoration of the wastes : "The enemy hath said against you, Aha, even the ancient high places are our's in possession. . . . But ye, O mountains of Israel, ye shall shoot forth your branches, and yield your fruit to my people of Israel ; for they are at hand to come. . . . And ye shall dwell in the land that I gave to your fathers" (vers. 2, 8, 28). For this end the one great and essential event is the breaking of the yoke of Babylon, to set Israel at liberty to return to his own land ; yet the prophet, speaking as he is moved by the Holy Ghost, never speaks of Babylon, but carefully avoids the mention of the name, even when referring to the enemies from whom Israel is to be delivered : "Surely in the fire of my jealousy have I spoken against the residue of the heathen, and against all Idumea, which have appointed my land into their possession with the joy of all their heart. . . . I will take you from among the heathen, and gather you out of all countries, and will bring you into your own land" (vers. 5, 24). Idumea and Egypt, and all heathen

countries together, did not stand in the way of Israel's restoration like Babylon alone, whose iron yoke it was that must be broken to set Israel free; and, apart from the immediate moving of the Holy Spirit, no motives can be assigned for the very remarkable, and it would almost have seemed impossible omission, except obedience to the Divine command to pray for the peace of that city, and desire for the safety of his countrymen by not provoking the anger of the king who held them in his grasp. It is the Lord Himself who speaks through the lips of the prophet, and his mind is one; to deliver Israel into the power of Babylon, to subject them as loyal subjects under that dominion, and to save them in the end by his own right arm alone in answer to their prayers. So Ezekiel concludes his prophecy with the words: "I will yet for this be enquired of by the house of Israel to do it for them."

The invocations of Divine vengeance on Babylon, which conclude the hundred and thirty-seventh Psalm, form no exception to the submissive attitude enjoined on the exiles and accepted by them, because the Psalm was evidently written after the release of the captives. On returning to Jerusalem they rehearse their past condition when they sat and wept by the rivers of Babylon; but the city was not destroyed when it was taken by Cyrus, and as before the Exile, so now after it, the still unfulfilled judgments are prophetically announced against Babylon (Is. xiii. 18; Ps. cxxxvii. 8).*

* "There can be *no doubt whatever* as to the time when this Psalm was written. It expresses the feelings of an exile who has but just returned from the land of his captivity. In all probability the writer was a Levite, who was one of the first, as soon as the edict of Cyrus was published, to return to Jerusalem. He is again in his own land. He sees again the old familiar scenes. Yet the change is terrible: the spoiler has been in his home, his vines and his fig-trees have been cut down, the house of his God is a heap of ruins. He takes his harp, the companion of his exile, the cherished relic of happier days,—the harp which he could not string at the bidding of his conquerors by the waters of Babylon; and now with faltering hand he sweeps the strings, first in low plaintive melancholy cadence pouring out his griefs, and then with a loud rush of wild and strong music, answering to the wild and strong numbers of his verse, he raises the pæan of vengeance over his foes."—PEROWNE.

"That the Psalm was sung after the return from Babylon is evident from the words in ver. 1-3, 'we sat, we wept.' It was at the second capture by Darius Hystaspes, eighteen years after the first, that Babylon's hundred gates were laid waste and her lofty walls prostrated. It is to this event that the statement (v. 8) must refer; for it is this properly that formed the first and the last destruction. The Divine retributive righteousness is taught, precisely as here, by our Lord in Matt. vii. 2: 'With what measure ye mete, it shall be measured to you again.'"—HENGSTENBERG.